

UNIT 3

Civic Education

Comprehensive Summary — All Headings Covered

Course: Citizenship and Transformative Education (CTE 80111)
College of Science and Technology | First Year CSE | 2025–2026
Prepared: March 22, 2026

Aim and Learning Outcomes

Unit 3 aims to expose students to the foundational concepts of citizenship, state-building, nation-building, and national identity, and to connect these concepts to Rwanda's own history.

By the end of the unit, students should be able to:

- Explain the notions and issues of citizenship, state building, nation building, and national identity.
 - Relate the history of Rwanda with issues of citizenship, state building, nation building, and national identity.
 - Portray an ideal Rwandan citizen.
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3.1 Concepts of Civic Education

The word 'civic' derives from the Latin *civis*, meaning citizen. Civic education — also called citizenship or democracy education — is a continual process of equipping individuals of all ages with the knowledge, skills, and values needed to participate actively and responsibly in a democratic society. It operates at local, national, and international levels through three channels:

- Formally — through schools and other educational institutions.
- Non-formally — through training, workshops, and programs like Urugerero.
- Informally — through family, church, and media.

3.1.1 The Goal of Civic Education

The overarching goal is to promote civic engagement and support democratic, participatory governance. Civic education builds an informed and engaged public — a necessary complement to efforts to improve the practice of good governance itself.

3.1.2 Elements of Civic Education

Civic education is built on three main elements:

- Civic Knowledge — understanding the political system, citizens' rights and responsibilities, concepts like separation of powers, and the history and geography that shape society.
- Civic Skills — intellectual skills (identifying, describing, analysing, evaluating, defending positions) and participatory skills (interacting, monitoring government, influencing political processes).
- Civic Dispositions — character traits that support democratic life: civility, respect for rights and the law, honesty, open-mindedness, critical-mindedness, patriotism, compassion, negotiation, and tolerance of ambiguity.

Civic education also covers civic duties (legally required obligations like paying taxes) and civic responsibilities (voluntary obligations such as voting, attending civic meetings, and helping others).

3.2 Nationhood and State Building

3.2.1 Nationhood

Nationhood refers to the collective identity, unity, and shared consciousness of a people who see themselves as a distinct political community within a defined territory. Its key elements include:

- A shared identity, 'we-feeling,' and solidarity among citizens.
- Political community under a common authority and legal system.
- Territorial integrity — a defined geographic space.
- Common values and goals expressed in national documents like the constitution.
- Civic responsibility — participation in national development and governance.
- Unity in diversity — cohesion despite ethnic, religious, or regional differences.

Nationhood promotes patriotism, fosters unity, encourages civic participation, builds state legitimacy, and strengthens societal resilience in times of crisis.

Key distinctions: Citizenship is a legal status with rights and duties. Nationhood is the emotional sense of belonging. Nationalism is an ideology prioritising a nation's interests. Nationhood is simply the condition of being a nation.

The Concept of Citizenship

Citizenship traces back to Ancient Greece. Etymologically from the Latin *civis* (citizen) and *civitas* (city). In the legal sense, citizenship is the formal relationship between an individual and the state, conferring rights and imposing duties. In the practical sense, it encompasses active participation in shaping one's community — local, national, or global.

Key features of democracy that underpin active citizenship include:

- Citizen participation, equality, political tolerance, and accountability.
- Transparency, regular free and fair elections, and acceptance of election results.
- Economic freedom, control of the abuse of power, and a bill of rights.
- Respect for human rights, a multi-party system, and the rule of law.

Dimensions of Citizenship

Citizenship has four dimensions that must be developed in balance:

- Political/Legal — rights and responsibilities vis-à-vis the political system.
- Social — behaviour and solidarity among individuals in society.
- Cultural — consciousness of common cultural heritage and history.
- Economic — relationship with the labour market and the right to work.

Ways of Acquiring Citizenship

Citizenship may be acquired through:

- Descent (*jus sanguinis*) — by blood from parents or grandparents.
- Birth on the territory (*jus soli*) — birthright citizenship.
- Marriage (*jus matrimonii*) — by marrying a citizen.
- Naturalization — after meeting residency and legal requirements.
- Investment (economic citizenship) — through substantial financial contribution.
- Adoption — for minors adopted from another country.
- Holding office (*jus officii*) — as in the Vatican City State.

Styles of Citizenship

- Dutiful citizenship — obedient, acting out of a sense of duty.
- Pragmatic citizenship — conforming to situations without deeper engagement.

- Outsider citizenship — inactive and disengaged, behaving like a stranger.
- Society-critic citizenship — responsible, independent-minded, and proactive.

Political Culture

Political culture is the set of beliefs, opinions, and emotions citizens hold toward their government. Almond and Verba (1963) identify three types:

- Parochial — citizens are uninformed and uninterested in politics.
- Subject — citizens are aware but remain only observers, leaving decisions to elites.
- Participant — citizens are informed, believe they can contribute, and actively engage in political processes.

Conceptions of Citizenship

- Liberal — stresses individual autonomy, rights, and self-interest.
- Republican — emphasises civic participation and freedom from arbitrary power.
- Communitarian — focuses on solidarity within cultural or ethnic groupings.
- Assimilationism — requires minorities to adopt the majority culture.
- Multiculturalism — allows diverse groups equal treatment while maintaining distinct identities.
- Cosmopolitanism — holds that all humans belong to a single global community deserving equal respect.

Models of Citizen Participation

Arnstein's Ladder of Participation (1969) identifies eight levels, from manipulation (non-participation) through tokenism (informing, consultation, placation) to genuine citizen power (partnership, delegated power, citizen control). The higher on the ladder, the more real power citizens hold.

Hart's Ladder of Youth Participation (1992) adapts this for children and young people, ranging from manipulation at the bottom to youth-initiated shared decision-making at the top, encouraging meaningful youth inclusion in all activities.

3.2.2 State Building and Nation Building

A state is an independent, sovereign government exercising control over a defined territory, characterized by four elements: population, territory, government, and sovereignty. A nation is a group sharing a strong sense of common identity — language, history, culture, or political aspirations — not necessarily limited to fixed borders.

A nation-state is a system where people with a common identity live under a single government within fixed borders — an ideal rarely fully achieved.

State building is the ongoing process of creating and strengthening institutions (legislatures, judicial systems, executive agencies, police, and military) to support long-term development. It is iterative and never completely finished.

Nation building (or nation formation) fosters a common identity among the governed — through shared symbols, culture, language, values, and myths transmitted via socialization. It runs parallel to state building, and success in one reinforces the other.

3.3 National Identity

3.3.1 Identity

Identity addresses the question 'Who are you?' Three types of identities exist: universal identity (traits distinguishing all people), social/group identity (religious, ethnic, cultural, gender, or national membership), and individual identity (how individuals define themselves and are defined by others). Identities are socially and historically constructed through interactions with family, peers, schools, media, and institutions.

3.3.2 National Identity

National identity is a person's sense of belonging to one state or nation, identified through its traditions, culture, history, language, and politics. It is not inborn but socially constructed through daily exposure to national symbols, shared history, language, and cultural experiences. It may change over time depending on psychosocial circumstances.

3.3.3 Components of National Identity

National identity comprises seven components:

- A subjective conviction of belonging to a particular nation.
- A strong sense of national affiliation as part of personal identity.
- Emotions (positive or negative) toward the nation.
- Stereotypes about characteristics of one's own and other national groups.
- A sense of inclusiveness and similarity with other group members.
- Opinions on current national aims and problems.
- Knowledge of and willingness to follow national cultural norms and values.

3.3.4 Measures of National Identity

National identity is measured through three dimensions:

- Identification with the nation — using 'we', taking criticism personally, seeing belonging as important to self-definition.
- Attitudes toward the country — pride, shame, belief in the country's qualities relative to others.
- National stereotypes — individual beliefs about traits of one's own and other nationalities (competence and morality).

The positive expression of national identity is patriotism (national pride and love for one's country). Its extreme form is chauvinism — the belief in absolute national superiority.

3.3.5 National Symbols

National symbols give concrete form to national identity. Key symbols include:

- National Flag — a modern invention popularised during the American and French revolutions. Rwanda's current flag was adopted on 25 October 2001, replacing the previous tricolour, to mark national unity after the genocide.
- National Anthem — Rwanda Nziza has been the national anthem since 1 January 2002. Its four stanzas celebrate heroism, Rwandan culture, patriotism, and the beauty and unity of Rwanda, replacing Rwanda Rwacu (1962).
- State Emblem (Coat of Arms) — the highest visual symbol of the state, used on official documents, passports, and currencies.

- National Calendar — organises official and commemorative dates, shaping national memory and collective identity by emphasising certain historical events and figures.

3.3.6 Overview of Rwanda's History in Connection with Citizenship, Nation and State Building

Four Phases of Rwanda's Nation Formation and State Building

Phase 1 — Pre-Colonial Period: Nation Formation

Before colonisation, Rwanda was a politically and culturally unified kingdom organised around the Nyiginya dynasty, founded by Gihanga. The society was united by:

- Shared clans (in which Hutu, Tutsi, and Twa all mixed equally).
- A common language — Kinyarwanda.
- Shared cultural and religious beliefs, and a shared land.
- The monarch (Umwami) — seen as the king of all people without distinction, above social categories.
- Itorero — the traditional youth education institution conveying national culture, patriotism, and values.

Hutu, Tutsi, and Twa were socio-economic classes, not ethnic groups. They spoke the same language, shared the same culture and beliefs, and intermarried. Rwanda was a politically, militarily, economically, and culturally unified nation.

Phase 2 — Colonial Period (1897–1962): State Building and Nation Re-shaping

German colonial rule (1897–1916) interfered little with social structures but banned Itorero and Rwanda's army. Belgian rule (1916–1962) fundamentally disrupted Rwandan nationhood:

- Based on the false Hamitic theory, Belgians defined the Tutsi as a foreign, superior race and the Hutu as inferior, turning socio-economic classes into ethnic groups.
- From 1923, discriminatory policies were introduced; in 1931, identity cards based on false ethnic categories became mandatory in all administrative documents.
- Colonial education, forced labour, and political mobilisation gradually built hatred and social division.
- In the 1950s, as Tutsi elites began demanding independence, Belgians switched allegiance to Hutu elites. This culminated in the organised Hutu Revolution of 1959, causing mass killings and the exile of hundreds of thousands of Tutsi.

Phase 3 — First and Second Republics (1962–1994): Discriminative Politics

Rwanda inherited a divided nation at independence. Both the First Republic (Grégoire Kayibanda) and the Second Republic (Juvénal Habyarimana) deepened divisionist politics:

- Systematic exclusion of Tutsi from education, employment, and political life.
- Cyclical killings of Tutsi throughout this period (1963–1967, 1973, 1990–1994).
- State-sponsored anti-Tutsi propaganda and impunity for ethnic violence.
- Ethnic and regional quotas (iringaniza) entrenching discrimination in schools and public service.

These failures of governance and human rights led to the formation of the RPF in 1987, the liberation war of 1990, and ultimately the 1994 Genocide against the Tutsi.

Phase 4 — After the Liberation War (1994–present): Nation and State Rebuilding

After the RPF ended the genocide on 4 July 1994, a national unity government faced the enormous task of rebuilding a nearly failed state. Key reconstruction measures included:

- Restoring security and repatriating refugees.
- Promoting peace, reconciliation, and justice for genocide survivors.
- Establishment of the National Unity and Reconciliation Commission.
- Revival of Itorero as a means of teaching Rwandan values.
- Establishment of community-based Gacaca Courts for genocide justice.
- Driving economic growth and national development.

Rwanda's History of the Genocide Against the Tutsi

The term 'genocide' was coined in 1944 by Raphael Lemkin and legally defined by the UN Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide (1948). Genocide includes acts committed with intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial, or religious group — including killing, causing serious harm, deliberately inflicting destructive conditions, preventing births, or forcibly transferring children.

History and Root Causes

The history of the genocide against the Tutsi is rooted in the colonial period and decades of systematic discrimination that followed independence. Key indicators of hatred ideology included:

- The Hutu Manifesto (1957) — explicitly advocated exclusion of Tutsi.
- The Hutu 10 Commandments (1959) — mobilised mass hatred, forbidding intermarriage, business relations, and employment of Tutsi.
- Propaganda via RTLM radio, Kangura newspaper, political parties, and artists like Simon Bikindi.

The genocide was triggered on 6 April 1994 by the death of President Habyarimana. Over 100 days (April–July 1994), more than one million Tutsi were killed, mostly by Hutu neighbours using traditional weapons, because ammunition was too expensive. The RPF ended the genocide on 4 July 1994.

The Role of the International Community

- United Nations — UNAMIR was present but its mandate prevented intervention. Requests to raid weapons stores were denied.
- France — materially supported the Habyarimana government; refused to rescue Tutsi, including those with French spouses.
- United States — chose not to intervene despite advance warning, due to concerns after the Somalia intervention.
- Holy See — some Catholic priests and nuns actively participated in or promoted genocide ideology. Pope Francis formally apologised in 2017.

Consequences of the Genocide

- Social — over one million killed; mass orphaning, widowing, displacement, disability, and HIV/AIDS spread.
- Psychological — severe trauma, loss of dignity, psychosocial damage to individuals and families.
- Cultural — culture of peace replaced by trauma and loss of traditional values.
- Economic — destruction of infrastructure, the school system, agriculture, and tourism.

- Political — tarnished state image, regional destabilisation, rise of extremism.
- International — failure of international community; 'never again' as a myth.

Never Again: Genocide Prevention Mechanisms

The Government of Rwanda has established a framework to make 'Never Again' a reality, including:

- Legal framework — Law No. 59/2018 on the Crime of Genocide Ideology.
- Institutional framework — National Commission for Fighting Against Genocide (CNLG), National Unity and Reconciliation Commission, National Itorero Commission, and FARG (Fund for Genocide Survivors).
- Citizenship education policies — Itorero and Ndi Umunyarwanda programs.

National Citizenship Policies: Itorero and Ndi Umunyarwanda

Rwanda confronted the enormous challenge of reestablishing national cohesion and a common national identity after the 1994 genocide. Two key government-led programs — Itorero and Ndi Umunyarwanda — address civic citizenship: the ideals, obligations, and shared identity of being Rwandan.

3.5.1 Itorero

Itorero is a revived traditional Rwandan institution — originally a communal school for instilling cultural values, patriotism, and social norms in youth. Re-established in 2007 and formalised by law in 2013 under the National Itorero Commission, it is now managed under the Ministry of National Unity and Civic Engagement (MINUBUMWE).

Primary objectives:

- To mould citizens with a high sense of patriotism, integrity, and social responsibility.
- To promote Rwandan culture, positive values, and unity.
- To disseminate national policies and development programs (like Vision 2050).
- To cultivate a spirit of volunteerism (Umutekano) and self-reliance.

Structure and implementation:

- Target Groups — youth, civil servants, private sector employees, local leaders, and diaspora. Participation is often mandatory for new civil servants and university entrants.
- Format — intensive residential camps (1–4 weeks) involving physical exercise, lectures, cultural activities (traditional dances, Ibyivugo poetry), and teamwork.
- Curriculum — national history, Rwandan values (Ubunyarwanda), key government policies, leadership, ethics, and combatting genocide ideology.

Recent evolution includes e-learning modules (Itorero Ry'imboni) to reach the diaspora. Critics argue it can enforce political conformity; the government defends it as essential for national cohesion.

Ndi Umunyarwanda ('I am Rwandan')

Launched in 2013, this national program aims to build a supra-ethnic national identity where the primary self-definition is 'Rwandan,' replacing historically emphasised ethnic identities of Hutu, Tutsi, and Twa.

Core methodology — community-based dialogue forums where participants:

- Engage in truth-telling about the genocide and colonial divisions.

- Offer apologies and forgiveness across ethnic lines.
- Deconstruct colonial myths about racial origins of ethnic groups.
- Pledge to embrace a shared Rwandan identity (Umunyarwanda).

Coordinated by NURC (now under MINUBUMWE), the program's philosophy is now embedded in school curricula, media, and public discourse. Critics debate whether it achieves deep reconciliation or suppresses legitimate discussion of ethnicity and historical grievances.

Synergy Between the Two Policies

- Itorero — the civic education and training arm that instills patriotic values and knowledge.
- Ndi Umunyarwanda — the dialogue and identity-building process that addresses historical wounds and psychological trauma.

Together they form a comprehensive strategy: Itorero trains the mind while Ndi Umunyarwanda heals the social fabric. Both work toward the same goal of ensuring that genocide never happens again.

General Conclusion

Rwanda's path of civic education, nationhood building, and state building is inseparable from its history — of pre-colonial unity, colonial disruption, post-independence discrimination, genocide, and post-genocide reconstruction. Citizenship education, through formal schooling, Itorero, and Ndi Umunyarwanda, is presented as essential for creating resilient, patriotic, and ethically grounded citizens who can sustain a peaceful, united, and developing Rwanda.

Rwanda has a strong cultural heritage — the Rwandan identity spirit — to build upon for developing a socially, economically, and politically resilient nation. This education must start from the heart of every Rwandan, and particularly from the youth elite, to internalize and live out the values of Rwandan identity in every sphere of life.